
AI and You

How to Identify AI in Student Work

Alex Sanna
October 17, 2025

How does AI work?

What You'll Likely See

- Large Language Models (LLMs) are the most common forms of AI you'll encounter
- These models ingest large amounts of text and analyze them to identify patterns in speech
 - They look for words/phrases that commonly follow other words, then build associations with them
 - They then use these patterns to assemble responses to prompts based on probability
- Teams of trainers provide inputs/prompts to the AI models, and then teams of human and computer models review the outputs
 - They assess relevance, completeness of response, concision, vocabulary, correctness, etc.



Let me just Google that...

Gemini is Google's LLM

It's capable of creating images, answering questions, creating documents, providing outlines, etc.

Students will commonly use it via the AI overview for a Google Search

The results are hit or miss, but frequently miss

The overview will provide citations for where it got the information, but in the process of condensing information, context is lost

A screenshot of a Google search interface with a dark theme. The search bar at the top contains the text "What does Norman Bowker carry?". Below the search bar is a navigation bar with tabs for "All", "Images", "Videos", "Forums", "Shopping", "Short videos", "More", and "Tools". The "All" tab is selected. Below the navigation bar is the "AI Overview" section, which provides a summary of the search results. The summary states: "In Tim O'Brien's novel *The Things They Carried*, Norman Bowker physically carries a diary and a severed thumb." Below the summary are two bullet points, each with a citation. The first bullet point is "A Diary: He uses the journal to record his thoughts and feelings during the war. This item shows his reflective and sensitive nature compared to some of the other soldiers." with a citation from "Internet Public Library +2". The second bullet point is "A Severed Thumb: Given to him by fellow soldier Mitchell Sanders, this dark brown thumb belonged to a teenage Viet Cong soldier. It serves as a grim, ironic item for Bowker, who is described as a gentle person, and symbolizes the brutality and senselessness of the war." with a citation from "Homework.Study.com +2". At the bottom of the AI Overview section is a button labeled "Show more" with a downward arrow.



ChatGPT

ChatGPT is owned by OpenAI, and they create multiple AI products, including numerous branches of ChatGPT for different professions

It can analyze images the user uploads and respond to questions about them

It can also create images based on prompts

It will help outline papers, answer essay prompts, and aid with research

What's on the agenda today?

+ Ask anything

Think



Create an image

Write or edit

Search the web

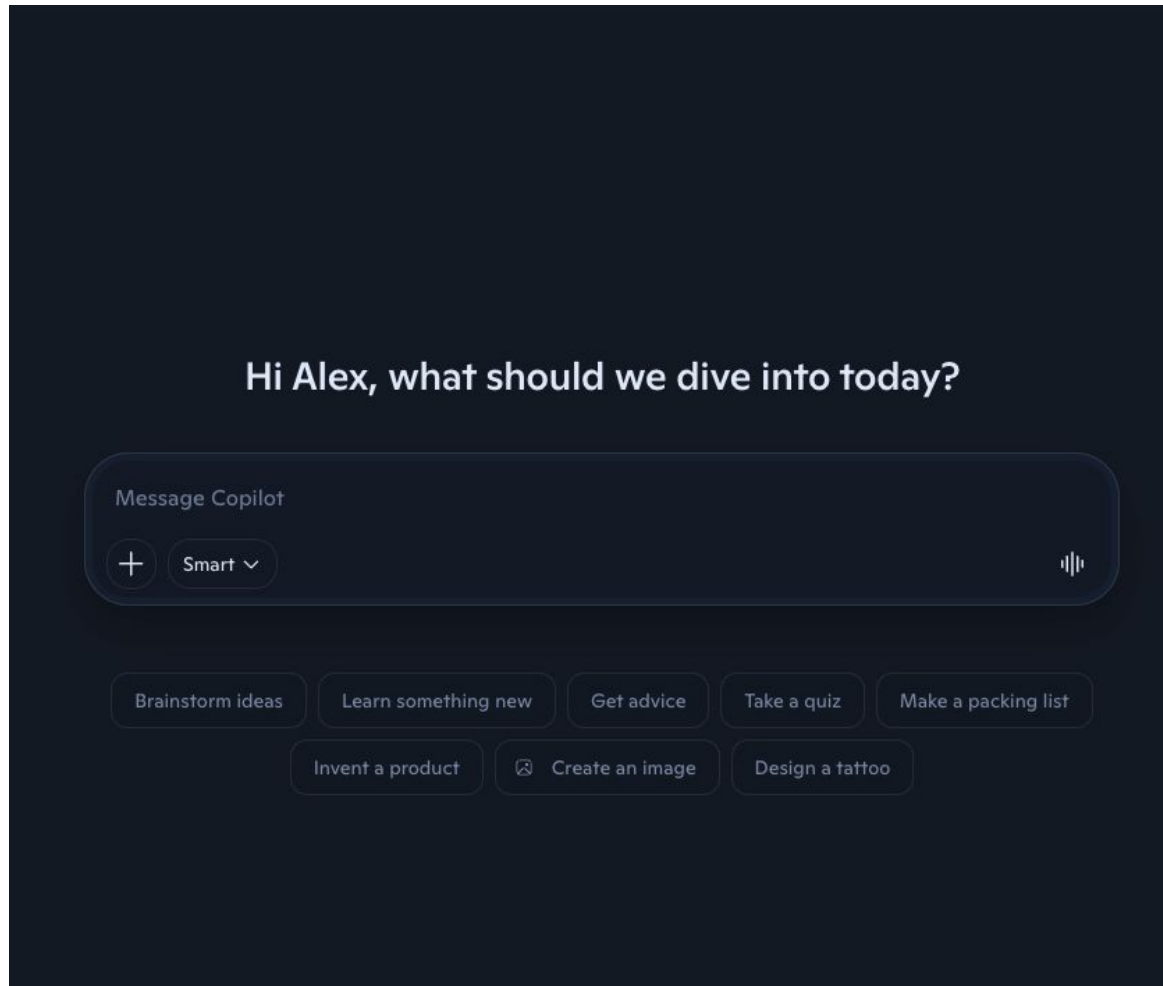


Copilot is Microsoft's AI, and it has a suite of tools and functionalities

It can respond to user prompts like Gemini and ChatGPT, and create similar outputs and products

It is an attractive option for our students, though, since it is integrated into Microsoft office products like Word and Outlook

Students have access directly in the tools they are using to complete school work



The Problem?



Copilot

Copilot is an AI and may make mistakes. Your conversation activity, which includes content you share, now helps train AI. [Opt out.](#)



Gemini

AI responses may include mistakes.



ChatGPT

ChatGPT can make mistakes. Check important info.



ChatGPT

The prompt:

Write an extended response that explains how Norman Bowker suffers from PTSD in the novel, "The Things they Carried." Use text evidence to support your answer.

The text evidence the AI came up with is a hallucination. It never appears in the text.

It is generally correct; the tone and theme matches what the chapter is about, but the quote is wrong

Finally, Bowker's emotional numbness is also a clear indication of his PTSD. He is unable to find joy in anything and is disconnected from his own feelings. In "Notes," Bowker writes, "There is no hope for me. I can't work up the courage to kill myself, so all I can do is cry." This statement highlights the sense of hopelessness and despair that can come with PTSD, as well as the difficulty in expressing and processing one's emotions.



The prompt:

Write an extended response that explains how Norman Bowker suffers from PTSD in the novel, "The Things they Carried." Use text evidence to support your answer.

Same issue here. This quote never appears in the text

His trauma is cyclically centered on the night his friend Kiowa drowned in the sewage field, and his overwhelming sense of failure manifests as emotional paralysis. The most striking evidence of this inability to move past the event is his continuous, aimless driving around the town lake. O'Brien writes, "The lake had been a fondness of his. It was where he spent his days now, a place to think, a place to park." This driving symbolizes his mental state: circling the traumatic event without ever resolving it, finding "nowhere to go."

Iron-clad Proof

— “Mr. Sanna, I did use AI...” —

How to Identify - Trust Your Instincts

- You are the experts in your content area.
 - *You know the curriculum and your material*
- If something feels “off” about a response, and the student has provided incorrect information, that is your first clue that they might have used AI
- While not ironclad on its own, there are some steps to investigate and gather more proof
- You are building a case so you may have a productive conversation with your student

Turnitin.com AI Detection

This tool provides another strong indicator that a piece was written with AI

The county pays for Turnitin.com and the suite of tools it provides

Turnitin has trained its detection tools in a similar way to the LLM training

It analyzes AI generated text and assesses a few key aspects

- Burstiness - How complex and varied the piece's sentence structure is
- Perplexity - Deals with word choice. Low perplexity scores mean that the words used are what you'd expect from an LLM

Three Tips for Writing Clear Content: Mastering the Art of Clarity

As writers, our goal is to craft content that effectively conveys our message and engages our audience. Achieving clarity in writing can make the difference between content that confuses and content that resonates with readers. To help you create clear, concise, and compelling content, we've compiled three essential tips. Master these, and you'll be well on your way to producing high-quality, impactful writing.

Simplify your language:

One of the most effective ways to improve clarity in your writing is to use simple language. This doesn't mean dumbing down your content; instead, it's about removing jargon, unnecessary words, and complicated sentence structures that can trip up your readers.

Here's how you can achieve this:

1. **Avoid jargon:** Jargon refers to specialized terminology used within specific fields or industries. While this language may be familiar to experts, it can confuse and alienate readers who aren't as well-versed in the subject matter. Replace jargon with simpler, more universally understood terms whenever possible.
2. **Use shorter sentences:** Long, complex sentences can be difficult to follow and may cause your reader to lose focus. Aim for an average sentence length of 15-20 words, and try to limit the use of conjunctions and clauses that can make sentences more convoluted.
3. **Remove unnecessary words:** Wordiness can muddle your message and make it harder for readers to grasp your point. Eliminate redundant or unnecessary words and phrases to streamline your writing.

Use the active voice:

The active voice makes your writing more direct, clear, and engaging. In the active voice, the subject of the sentence performs the action, while in the passive voice, the subject is acted upon. Compare these two examples:

Passive: The cake was baked by Sarah. Active: Sarah baked the cake.



Document Version History

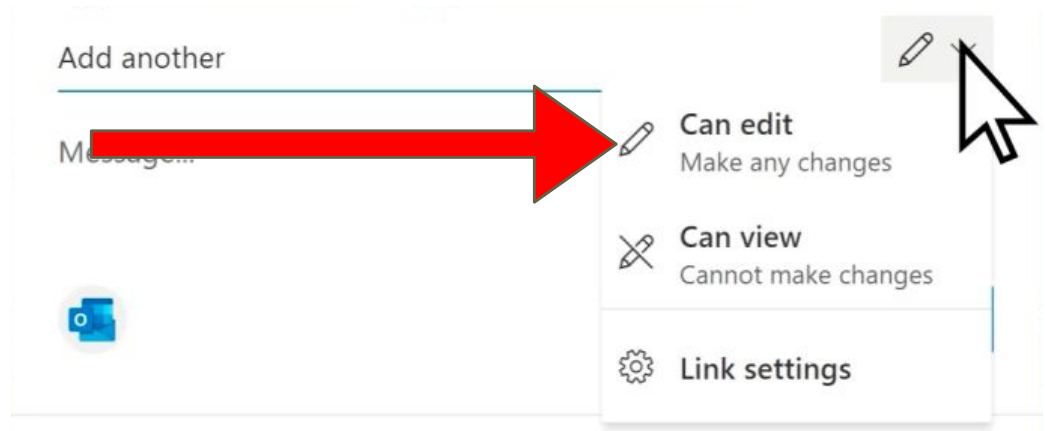
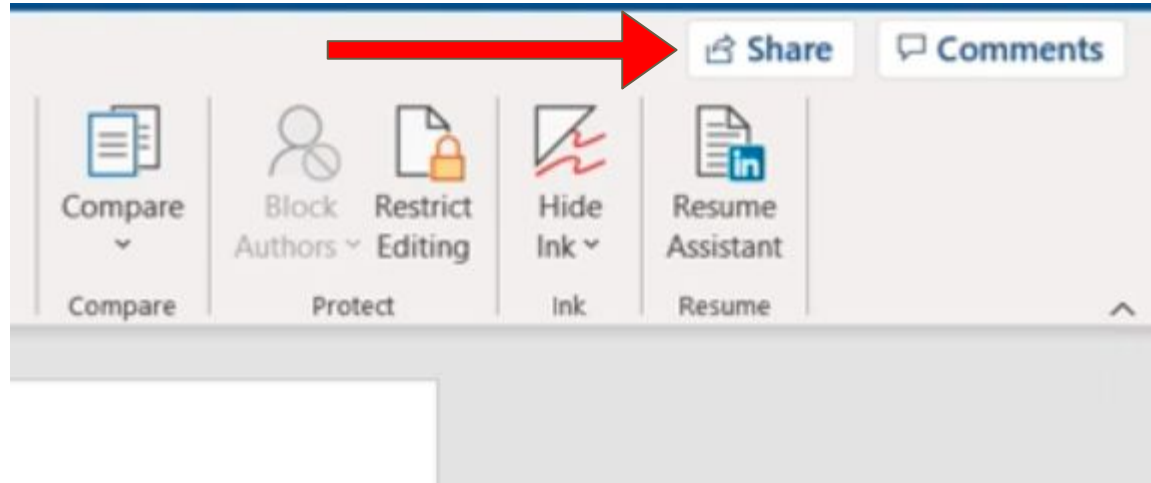
Word Online tracks every change an editor makes

You can access this tool if you have edit permissions for the document

If you suspect a student has used AI and want to verify, ask them to share the document with you with Edit Permission

If they agree to, you can verify

If they don't, you can escalate to Administration and they can access the document for you



New text is shown in red. A large block of red text indicates that the student copied and pasted from somewhere, in this case a LLM output

The screenshot shows a document editor interface. The top bar includes a search bar with the text "Search for tools, help, and more (Option + Q)" and a "Back to document" button. The document content is displayed in a central pane, with a large block of red text indicating copied content. The text is as follows:

message or focus:

In To Kill a Mockingbird and its film adaptation, To Kill a Mockingbird, the filmmakers compress many details and scenes from the novel in order to create a more focused and emotionally powerful story for the screen. Harper Lee's novel includes many side stories, long descriptions of Maycomb, and detailed moments from Scout's childhood, but the film narrows its attention mostly to the trial of Tom Robinson and Atticus Finch's role in it. By simplifying certain events and characters, the movie is able to fit the story into a shorter runtime while emphasizing its central themes of justice, racism, and moral courage.

One major way the film compresses the novel is by reducing the amount of time spent on Scout, Jem, and Dill's everyday childhood adventures. In the book, readers learn many small details about life in Maycomb, including school experiences, family history, and neighborhood gossip. The movie keeps some important scenes involving Boo Radley and the children, but many smaller moments are removed or shortened. For example, Aunt Alexandra's role is greatly reduced, and several chapters about Scout learning social expectations are either cut completely or only briefly mentioned. This allows the film to move more quickly toward the courtroom scenes, which become the emotional center of the movie.

The filmmakers likely made these choices because movies have limited time and need a clearer central conflict. A novel can spend chapters building atmosphere and character development, but a film must communicate ideas more quickly through visuals and dialogue. By focusing heavily on the trial, the adaptation highlights Atticus Finch as the moral center of the story. Gregory Peck's performance as Atticus becomes the heart of the film, showing calm

The right sidebar shows the "Version History" for the document. It lists several versions, with the most recent being "Yesterday, 9:13 PM" (Current Version). The sidebar also includes a "Show edits" toggle and a "Back to document" button.

Version	Changes
Yesterday, 10:30 PM	ssle modified
Yesterday, 10:30 PM	le modified
Yesterday, 10:20 PM	modified
Yesterday, 9:13 PM	modified
Thursday, 3:43 PM	le modified
Thursday, 3:40 PM	modified and renamed
Thursday, 10:00 AM	modified and renamed

The student will then go through and change certain words to avoid AI detection tools and to make the tone sound more human

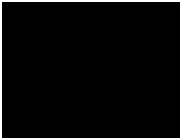
Chrome File Edit View History Bookmarks Profiles Tab Window Help

Clever | Portal Apps | M365 Copilot Hon. Film & Lit 1960s Essay

livecarrollk12-my.sharepoint.com/:w:/r/personal/raw7676_star_carrollk12_org/_layouts/15/doc2.aspx?sourcedoc=%7B65652F65-3A4F-4870-BDA6-142A99E60392%7D&file=Hon.%20Film%20%26%20Lit%201960s%20Essay.doc...

Hon. Film & Lit 1960s Essay Search for tools, help, and more (Option + Q)

Back to document Yesterday, 10:20 PM Save a Copy Restore



To Kill a Mockingbird

How does the film compress details and scenes from Harper Lee's novel? Why might the filmmakers have made these choices, and how do they shape the film's message or focus?

In To Kill a Mockingbird and its film adaptation, To Kill a Mockingbird of the same name, the filmmakers compress ~~many~~multiple details and scenes from the novel in order to create a more focused and emotionally powerful story for the screen. ~~Harper Lee's movie. The~~ novel includes many side stories, ~~long descriptions of Maycomb, and~~and ~~incredibly~~ detailed moments from Scout's childhood, but the film ~~narrows its attention mostly to makes itself mainly focused on~~ the trial of Tom Robinson ~~and Atticus Finch's role in it~~. By simplifying ~~certain events and characters~~the story in the movie, the movie is able to ~~fit~~turn the story into a shorter ~~runtime~~story while ~~still~~ emphasizing its central themes of justice, racism, and moral courage.

~~One major~~A large way the film compresses the novel ~~is~~by reducing the amount of time spent on Scout, Jem, and Dill's ~~everyday childhood~~ adventures. In the book, ~~readers learn~~the reader learns many ~~small~~ details about life in Maycomb, ~~including like Scout's first day at school experiences, family,~~ the history of the Finch family, and neighborhood gossip. The movie keeps some ~~important~~

Version History

Show edits ☒

Yesterday, 10:30 PM Current Version

Yesterday, 10:30 PM modified

Yesterday, 10:30 PM modified

Yesterday, 10:20 PM modified

Yesterday, 9:13 PM modified

Thursday, 3:43 PM modified

Thursday, 3:40 PM modified and renamed

Thursday, 10:00 AM modified and renamed

WordPageNumber

The final product will look something like this, a few small changes before submitting

The screenshot shows a document editor interface with a dark theme. The top bar includes a search bar with the text "Search for tools, help, and more (Option + Q)", a "Back to document" button, and a "Yesterday, 10:30 PM" timestamp. Below the top bar, there are two buttons: "Save a Copy" and "Restore". The main content area displays a document titled "To Kill a Mockingbird". The document text is as follows:

How does the film compress details and scenes from Harper Lee's novel? Why might the filmmakers have made these choices, and how do they shape the film's message or focus?

In *To Kill a Mockingbird* and its film adaptation of the same name, the filmmakers compress multiple details and scenes from the novel in order to create a more emotionally powerful story for the movie. The novel includes many side stories and incredibly detailed moments from Scout's childhood, but the film makes itself mainly focused on the trial of Tom Robinson. By simplifying the story in the movie, the movie is able to turn the story into a shorter story while still emphasizing its central themes of justice, and racism, and moral courage.

A large way the film compresses the novel by reducing the amount of time spent on Scout, Jem, and Dill's adventures. In the book, the reader learns many details about life in Maycomb, like Scout's first day at school, the history of the Finch family, and neighborhood gossip. The movie keeps some scenes, namely the ones with Boo Radley and the children, but many scenes are removed or shortened and simply just explained. For example, in the book on Scout's first day of school, her teacher yells at her and tells her that Atticus had taught her to read all wrong and that Atticus needs to stop teaching her how to read. In the movie, the scene is simplified to Scout crying and telling Atticus, which had happened in the book,

The right sidebar shows a "Version History" panel with a "Show edits" toggle. The history list includes:

- Yesterday, 10:30 PM (Current Version)
- Yesterday, 10:30 PM (ie modified)
- Yesterday, 10:30 PM (ie modified)
- Yesterday, 10:20 PM (modified)
- Yesterday, 9:13 PM (modified)
- Thursday, 3:43 PM
 - Thursday, 3:43 PM (modified)
 - Thursday, 3:40 PM (modified and renamed)
- Thursday, 10:00 AM (modified and renamed)

The bottom left corner of the interface shows the text "WordPageNumber".

AI Writing Patterns

There are also a few writing patterns that AI frequently employs

- Parallel structure
- Rule of Threes
- Perfect — and uncommon — punctuation

While not proof on their own that the piece is written by AI, it is another indicator

Again, you are working to build a case for when you have the conversation with the student

Parallel structure

I came, I saw, I conquered

Parallel Structure refers to sentences that mirror each other

This is often used to emphasize the relation between ideas, either strongly contrasting or pointing out comparisons

This is a natural speech pattern for humans, but it is also mathematical and reflects the way that AI learns to “speak”

It's not just __; it's __.

Not only does this __, it __.

It would appear that __ , so we should __ instead.

Rule of Threes

We like groups of three;
something about it feels
complete

As such, Als have been trained
to associate groups/lists of
three ideas as clear and
effective communication

It is so reliant on this
structure that it acts as a
default of sorts

*The novel explores themes such
as grief, mental health, and
healing.*

*The movie uses dramatic
lighting, rapid editing, and
minimal dialogue to convey...*

Perfect – and Unusual – Punctuation

How many people here know when to use a Semicolon?

How many people know what key combination produces an em dash?

How many people know what an em dash is and how to use one?

Perfect – and Unusual – Punctuation

AI has learned how to properly punctuate virtually any sentence it writes, and it has an entire set of punctuation marks at its disposal

If a student starts using a new punctuation mark seemingly out of nowhere, that can be an indicator that they used AI

A semicolon is kind of like a period; it marks the end of a sentence, but connects the following sentence back to the previous.

An em dash is useful for when you want a pause in your sentence — and you're tired of using commas or parentheses — to emphasize a point.

Building a Case

The goal of all this investigatory work is to strengthen your case when you have a conversation with the student

Give them the chance to come clean and own their mistake; this turns what was going to be strictly punitive into a learning opportunity

Students will continue to use AI if it goes unaddressed; they should be encouraged to think about why hard work is valuable

Encountering Resistance

If they are resistant to the conversation, then you can refer them to administration

Send along a short write up and any other evidence you collected

Using AI is academic dishonesty, and it will be treated as any other instance would be treated

Some Crucial Weaknesses

Work from Multi-Language Learners (MLL) often comes up as false positives for AI

This makes sense; they are learning the language and how to write in a similar fashion that the LLMs learned

Recognize and practice patterns of good writing in English

If a MLL student's work comes up as AI, check with our support staff and ask their opinion

Some Crucial Weaknesses

There are also plenty of students who write in a very formulaic fashion

Their voice and word choice simply mimics the style a lot of LLMs use

It's how they were taught

This is why you should always approach AI usage as you would any other infraction

Make it a conversation and a chance to treat the student with respect to their person and autonomy

The Order of Operations

1. Notice something “off” in the student work
2. Review AI-detection results as one additional signal
3. Examine document history
4. Discuss the work/process with the student
5. Follow district policy

The Process

Something's Off

You read a student's work and something strikes your ear as odd or unusual

A fact is wrong, a quote is made up, or something else makes you pause

Start investigating

Ai Detectors

Use Turnitin's AI detector as a starting point. It can be a strong indicator that AI was used in the writing process

However, be wary; AI detectors can return false positives

Review Document History

Ask the student to share the document with you

Make sure they set you to have Edit Permission

Look for anomalies in the Version History that indicate they copied and pasted their text from somewhere

Discuss

Talk to the student. Aim to have a productive conversation about the concerns you noticed and encourage them to admit to their mistake

This is a chance to learn and correct the issue

Escalate

If the student is resistant, or even becomes hostile in the face of all your evidence, escalate to Administration

Forward any evidence you collected in the course of investigating

Then follow district policy for Academic Dishonesty

Sources and Further Reading

"Large Language Models Explained Briefly ." *Youtube*, 3Blue1Brown, 20 Nov. 2024,

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LPZh9BOjkQs&feature=youtu.be>.

"AI Writing Detection: What Academic Leaders Need to Know." *Turnitin.Com*, Turnitin, 21 Sept. 2025,

<https://www.turnitin.com/blog/ai-writing-detection-what-academic-leaders-need-to-know>.

"I Can Spot Ai Writing Instantly — Here's How You Can Too." *Youtube*, Evan Edinger, 8 June 2025,

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9Ch4a6ffPZY&feature=youtu.be>.

The Impact of AI Bypassers on Academic Integrity | *Turnitin*. 27 Aug. 2025,

<https://www.turnitin.com/blog/navigating-ai-misuse-tackling-the-impact-of-ai-bypassers-on-academic-integrity>.